whole career. Peter Taylor might have taken a risk with me and with the team, but I don't think we let him or England down. We lost 1–0 to a very strong Italian side but deserved better. Emile Heskey terrified their defense all night long and we made plenty of chances but couldn't score. Personally, I knew I'd never felt like this playing for England. Since that night, people have said to me that they saw a change in me almost as soon as I pulled on that England armband. I know the incident they have in mind when they say that.

We were about ten minutes into the second half and it was still 0–0. We'd had a couple of half-shouts for penalties earlier in the game. This time, the ball got crossed in and ricocheted up in the air. I didn't know where the challenge came from but I remember being barged out of the way as the ball dropped towards me. It was in the area and a couple of England players appealed for the foul. I went down on the floor. As I got myself to my feet, the player who I guess had bumped me, Gattuso, was shouting and screaming at me. Maybe he thought I'd gone down too easily. Or that acting angry would keep him out of trouble with the referee. Anyway, I went to run off and he grabbed hold of my shirt. I turned back and looked at him. It was the kind of split-second which, in the past, might have seen me react in the wrong way. Here, I just wanted to get on with it: I was England captain and had to be bigger than that. I jogged away from him. And from trouble. In the end, Gattuso got away with it. A couple of minutes later, he scored with a screamer from thirty yards which turned out to be the winner.

Peter Taylor had done a really good job. The new England coach was in the stands in Turin that night. The argument about a foreigner, Sven-Goran Eriksson, taking over running the national team had been going on for a couple of weeks. It even came up in the England dressing room. I understood people's concerns. I know they wanted an Englishman who'd be up to taking on the responsibility of being in charge of the England team. But the situation we found ourselves in was that the country was desperate for success, desperate to see the national team play some decent soccer. We needed to get the best man for the job, whatever his background. And Sven was, and is, one of the most respected managers in the game. Fortunately, it didn't take long for most of the doubters to forget all their worries about the fact that Sven was a Swede: the results and, just as important, England's performances soon saw to that.

Before he took the England job, I'd never met Sven. I don't think I'd even played against any of the club sides he'd managed. In soccer, though, you know bosses by their reputations: word gets round about the very best. That, and the trophies he'd won, told you the new man deserved our respect. I was